

YASBANT NEGI



OMAR ABDULLAH | NC PRESIDENT

Sleeping with the Separatists

In the beginning, Omar Abdullah was widely seen as a victim of PDP's "foul" politics of twisting most of its rhetoric into anti-Abdullah diatribe. Nothing seemed to be working for the young Abdullah who had been trying hard to shed the baggage that his father Farooq Abdullah and grandfather late Sheikh Abdullah have become for the party he inherited. Outrage in Kashmir over the land transfer order provided him the opportunity to put down his arch rival Mehbooba Mufti, who tried to distance herself from the cabinet decision on the land deal. The young Abdullah scion also wanted the deal to be cancelled and the people to forget his party's role in creating a shrine board through the legislation that is now being perceived in the Valley to have created a "state within a state".

Omar's efforts at appealing to his

Kashmiri constituency reached a crescendo when he delivered a fiery speech in Parliament during the recent trust vote. His vow to fight for "every inch of Kashmir's land" won him some meaningless sympathy in the Muslim Valley, but turned him into a Ravana for the Hindus of Jammu. The nationalist with an appeal across the state reduced himself into a Valley politician. His party that has for long enjoyed the status of being the largest party in the state fell to the pulls of extreme tension between Jammu and Kashmir. As party head, Omar conveniently, and perhaps irresponsibly, sided with the Valley adding weight to the wedge that is dividing the state's two regions more sharply than ever before. His quest for becoming a hero for Kashmir made him a villain in Jammu.

by Alijaz Hussain

"IT IS THE ISSUE OF OUR LAND AND FOR OUR LAND, WE WILL FIGHT TILL WE DIE."

Omar Abdullah, NC President

GHULAM NABI AZAD | FORMER CHIEF MINISTER

Lost Communicator

How could a man known for his shrewd political manoeuvres make such a blunder? First, the then chief minister glibly agreed to former governor S.K. Sinha's demand for giving the land to the Shri Amarnath Shrine Board. Some say that he did this to woo the Hindu vote in Jammu on the eve of the upcoming Assembly elections. Later, when the PDP and the Hurriyat protested, Ghulam Nabi Azad failed to counter their propaganda and convince the common man that there was no physical transfer of land. In fact in the July 1 order that revoked the May 26 order, Azad claims that he had offered more to the Hindu pilgrims. But again his famed communication skills deserted him. He failed to sway the Amarnath Sangharsh Samiti, which left him

in a strange dilemma. Since he had never allotted the land to the board in the first place, how could he now "allot" it back?

At the fag end of his chief ministerial rule, Azad got himself into a needless controversy. He has been accused of using the then governor Sinha against the PDP to keep his allies in check. Moreover, the Centre claims that Azad did not brief it adequately about the gravity of the situation as he wanted to control it himself. Azad knew that his stint in the state was drawing to an end and was keen to begin his rehabilitation at the Centre on a positive slate. That didn't happen, and what really happened back home hasn't helped his ambitions to return to Delhi's durbar either.

by Priya Sahgal

SIPRA DAS



"IT WAS AN ACTION TAKEN IN GOOD FAITH. NOBODY REALISED THAT THINGS WOULD COME TO SUCH A STAGE."

Ghulam Nabi Azad, Former Chief Minister